

1,317
TOTAL BIRD SPECIES IN INDIA

942
SPECIES UNDER ASSESSMENT

DECLINE IN 30 YEARS

98
SPECIES IN RAPID DECLINE (BY OVER 50%)

106
IN DECLINE (BY OVER 25%)

98
STABLE

19
INCREASE (BY 25%)

17
RAPID INCREASE (BY 50%)

Source: SoIB, 2023

THREATS TO INDIA'S BIRDS

LOSS OF HABITAT: Forest degradation, change in geography of open habitats, loss of wetlands, riverine nesting places and coastal habitats, owing to urbanisation, infrastructural developments and change in land use patterns. Then there's the rise of monoculture plantations—such as commercial teak, oil palm, tea and coffee plantations—which support fewer bird species than natural forests

CLIMATE CHANGE: Global temperature has risen by 0.8°C in the past 150 years, causing dehydration and exhaustion in birds. Erratic climate patterns also impact avian nesting and breeding behaviour

AVIAN DISEASE: The impact of avian disease on the shrinking bird population in India has not been well researched or documented. In 2020-21, outbreaks of avian influenza across many Indian states resulted in heavy mortality among wild birds

URBAN INFRA: Sound pollution and bright lights of cities may cause disorientation in birds, pushing them to alter their behaviour: urban noise may cause them to sing louder, or at different frequencies. Collisions with glass facades of buildings, wind turbines and power lines are other threats

ILLEGAL HUNTING AND TRADE: Birds continue to be removed from the wild and sold for meat or for entertainment. Thirty-seven seizures of poached birds reported in India in 2020 showed parakeets, owls and vultures to be among species at threat

LACK OF FOOD: Availability of food resources greatly affects bird populations. In India, the most visible decline in numbers has been witnessed among birds that feed on vertebrates and carrion. This implies the presence of contaminants in food

POLLUTION: Exposure to toxic chemicals—heavy metal pollutants, plastics and organophosphates in insecticides—causes hormone disruption in birds, alterations in feeding behaviour and compromised immune system

International Union for Conservation of Nature, has played a seminal role in conserving biodiversity, directing policy and effort towards species that need protection the most. Its red list has nine categories, of which three—'Critically Endangered', 'Endangered', 'Vulnerable'—are considered to be threatened with extinction. And there are 182 Indian avian species among the 1,354 that figure in this red list.

There is no escaping the hard truth. India is losing its birds. A fact that the State of India's Birds (SoIB) 2023 report, released in August 2023, only corroborated. And that cannot be good news. "Several birds endemic to India, including the floricans and the bustards, could go extinct if we don't reverse their decline," says Vivek Menon, founder trustee and executive director of the Wildlife Trust of India, which was among the 13 Indian wildlife organisations that supported the SoIB initiative. The report, which assessed 942 of India's 1,317 bird species, concluded that 60 per cent of 338 species (for which there was sufficient data) showed long-term decline over 30 years and 40 per cent of 359 species exhibited annual decline for the past eight years. More specifically, it classified 178 species as high priority for conservation, given that indicators of their abundance have declined considerably in the long term and continue to decline today. The tag is also applied if their current range is very restricted, or if they appear among the globally threatened species in the IUCN red list. Another 323 species are classified as moderate priority. It also recommends 14 species for IUCN red list assessment, among them the Indian roller (*Coracias benghalensis*), known locally as the 'neelkanth' for its characteristic blue plumage, which is